

Urinary Tract Infection in Women aged 16 to 64

Patient Group Direction, version 002, issued 8 September 2026. Two medicines: nitrofurantoin first line, trimethoprim only where nitrofurantoin is unsuitable.

Scope and the order of choice

This PGD authorises the supply of an antibiotic for the treatment of uncomplicated lower urinary tract infection in non-pregnant women aged 16 to 64 years.

- **NITROFURANTOIN IS FIRST LINE. Supply trimethoprim only where nitrofurantoin is unsuitable for this patient, and record the reason.**
- Trimethoprim resistance in E. coli is common and is not predictable at the counter. Nitrofurantoin retains high urinary activity and is the NICE first choice.
- **ONE COURSE PER EPISODE. If the patient has already had an antibiotic for this same episode, from anyone, do not supply a second course. Refer.**
- **Ask the red flag questions in Appendix 1 before supplying anything. If any is present, refer and do not supply.**
- **Give 48 hour safety netting to every patient and record that you did.**
- **This PGD does not cover men, children, pregnant or breastfeeding women, catheterised patients, recurrent UTI, or any patient with signs of upper urinary tract infection. Refer.**
- This PGD does not cover prophylaxis or the prevention of recurrent infection.

Recurrent UTI: the definition that applies

- **Recurrent UTI means 2 or more episodes in the last 6 months, or 3 or more in the last 12 months. Ask both questions and record both answers.**
- A patient meeting that definition is EXCLUDED from this PGD and referred for investigation, whatever their current symptoms.

Sexually transmitted infection

- Vaginal discharge, pelvic pain, intermenstrual or post-coital bleeding, or a new or recent sexual partner should raise chlamydia, gonorrhoea and trichomonas as alternative diagnoses.
- **Where discharge is present, or the history raises the possibility, do not supply under this PGD. Refer for testing.**

Nitrofurantoin, first line

Patient Group Direction for the supply of nitrofurantoin 100mg modified release capsules for the treatment of uncomplicated lower urinary tract infection in non-pregnant women aged 16 to 64 years.

Healthcare professionals covered, and training

- Pharmacist registered and practising with the GPhC.
- Pharmacy technician registered and practising with the GPhC.
- All users must be familiar with the current SPC for the product supplied, the BNF, and the NICE guideline on lower urinary tract infection in women (NG109) and NICE CKS.
- All users must be able to distinguish a lower urinary tract infection from pyelonephritis, and must know the red flags in Appendix 1 without looking them up.
- All users must be competent to take a sexual history sufficient to consider a sexually transmitted infection as an alternative diagnosis, and to refer for testing without embarrassment on either side.
- All users must previously have supplied medicines under a PGD.
- All users must understand capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.
- All users must be up to date with CPD and appraisal, and with MHRA safety alerts relating to these medicines.
- All users must hold appropriate indemnity covering this service, must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer, and must practise only within the bounds of their own competence.

The PGD

Indication	Treatment of uncomplicated lower urinary tract infection in a non-pregnant woman aged 16 to 64 years, presenting with dysuria, urinary frequency, urgency or suprapubic discomfort, in the absence of any red flag in Appendix 1. This is the first line medicine under this PGD.
Inclusion criteria	• Female, aged 16 to 64 years inclusive. • Two or more of: dysuria, new nocturia, urinary frequency or urgency. Where only one symptom is present, refer rather than supply. • Symptoms present for 7 days or fewer. • No red flag in Appendix 1 present. • No antibiotic already taken for this episode. • Renal question answered as set out below. • Able to give valid informed consent, and consent given. • No exclusion criterion present.
Exclusion criteria	Refer, do not supply, where any of the following applies. • Male. Any UTI in a man is complicated by definition and needs assessment. • Aged under 16 or 65 and over. • Pregnant, possibly pregnant, or breastfeeding. Ask; do not assume. Nitrofurantoin is also avoided at term because of neonatal haemolysis. • ANY red flag in Appendix 1: fever, rigors, loin or flank pain, nausea or vomiting, visible haematuria, confusion or new drowsiness, or the patient appearing systemically unwell. • Known kidney disease, or renal function unknown in a patient aged 60 to 64. See the renal row below. • An indwelling urinary catheter, or a catheter removed within the last 7 days. Catheter-associated infection is not uncomplicated UTI and does not respond to a 3 day course. • Recurrent UTI, meaning 2 or more episodes in the last 6 months or 3 or more in the last 12 months. • An antibiotic already taken for this same episode, whether supplied here, by a GP, or obtained elsewhere. One course per episode. Refer. • Symptoms present for more than 7 days. • Known hypersensitivity to nitrofurantoin or to any excipient in the

	product supplied. ● Glucose-6-phosphate dehydrogenase (G6PD) deficiency. Nitrofurantoin causes haemolysis. Ask where the patient or their family originates from an area where G6PD deficiency is common. ● Previous pulmonary reaction, peripheral neuropathy or hepatic reaction attributed to nitrofurantoin. ● Acute porphyria. ● Vaginal discharge, pelvic pain, intermenstrual or post-coital bleeding, or a history suggesting a sexually transmitted infection. Refer for testing. ● Known structural or functional abnormality of the urinary tract, renal stones, or immunosuppression. ● Valid informed consent not obtained.
Renal function, how to assess it here	Ask the patient directly: "Have you ever been told you have kidney disease, or that your kidneys do not work as well as they should?" ● Answer YES, or the patient is under any renal follow-up: EXCLUDE. Refer. ● Answer NO and aged 16 to 59: proceed. ● Answer NO but aged 60 to 64, or the patient does not know: EXCLUDE. Refer for a renal function check first.
Cautions	Diabetes, and any condition causing peripheral neuropathy, increase the risk of nitrofurantoin-associated neuropathy. Counsel on new numbness or tingling and to stop and seek advice. Advise the patient the medicine must be taken with food or milk, both to reduce nausea and because absorption is better. Warn that urine may turn dark yellow or brown. This is harmless and expected. Advise the patient to complete the full 3 day course even if symptoms settle sooner. Encourage fluids and offer paracetamol or ibuprofen for pain as a separate pharmacy sale, subject to the usual checks.
Actions if the patient is excluded or declines	Explain why supply is not appropriate and what to do instead. Direct to the GP the same day where a red flag is present, or to NHS 111 or urgent care out of hours. Give the 48 hour and immediate-action advice regardless of whether anything is supplied. Document the advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate.
Safety netting, to be given to every patient	48 HOURS. Tell the patient, in these terms: "If you are no better in 48 hours, or you get worse at any point, contact your GP or NHS 111 the same day. Do not wait." Tell the patient to seek help IMMEDIATELY, not in 48 hours, if any of the following develops: ● A temperature, shivering or shaking uncontrollably. ● Pain in the back or side, below the ribs. ● Feeling sick or being sick. ● Blood in the urine that they can see. ● Confusion, drowsiness, or feeling very unwell in themselves. ● Any new pain or bleeding in pregnancy, if pregnancy is a possibility.

The medicine

Name, form and strength	Nitrofurantoin 100mg modified release capsules.
Legal category	POM.
Dose and frequency	100mg twice daily for 3 days.

Quantity supplied	6 capsules. A 3 day course. No repeat supply under this PGD.
Route and method	Oral, with food or milk.
Maximum treatment period	3 days. One course per episode. A patient still symptomatic at 48 hours is referred, not re-supplied.
Storage	Store in the original packaging below 25 degrees Celsius.
Drug interactions	Antacids containing magnesium trisilicate reduce absorption; separate them. Probenecid and sulfinpyrazone reduce urinary excretion and so reduce efficacy while increasing toxicity. Quinolones are antagonised. Check the current SPC and BNF for the patient's full medicine list.
Adverse effects	Common: nausea, headache, flatulence, diarrhoea, dark or brown urine. Uncommon: rash, pruritus. Rare but serious: acute and chronic pulmonary reactions, peripheral neuropathy, hepatic reactions including hepatitis, haemolytic anaemia in G6PD deficiency.
Yellow Card reporting	Report suspected adverse reactions via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP.
Records to be kept	• That valid informed consent was given. • Patient name, address, date of birth, and the GP with whom they are registered. • The symptoms present, and how long they have been present. • That the red flags in Appendix 1 were asked about and were absent. • The answer given on known kidney disease, and the answer given on previous episodes in the last 6 and 12 months. • Which medicine was supplied and why. Where trimethoprim was supplied, the reason nitrofurantoin was unsuitable. • Name, form, strength, dose, quantity and date of supply. • That 48 hour safety netting was given, and what the patient was told to do. • Name and registration number of the healthcare professional supplying. • Advice given, including advice given if the patient is excluded or declines. • Details of any adverse drug reactions and the actions taken. • That the medicine was supplied under this PGD. Records signed, dated, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records are acceptable. Adults aged 18 and over: keep for 8 years. Under 18s: keep until the 25th birthday, or the 26th birthday where the patient was 17 when treatment finished.
Disposal	Advise the patient to return any unused medicine to a pharmacy. Do not flush or place in household waste.

Information for the patient

Written information	Supply the patient information leaflet provided with the product.
Counselling	• Take one capsule twice a day for 3 days, with food or milk. Finish the course. • Your urine may go dark yellow or brown. That is expected and harmless. • Drink plenty of fluids. • Paracetamol or ibuprofen can be used for the pain if they suit you. • Stop and seek advice if you develop new numbness, tingling or pins and needles, or if you become short of breath.

Follow-up

As set out in the safety netting row above. 48 hours, or immediately for any red flag symptom.

Trimethoprim, second line only

Patient Group Direction for the supply of trimethoprim 200mg tablets for the treatment of uncomplicated lower urinary tract infection in non-pregnant women aged 16 to 64 years, where nitrofurantoin is unsuitable.

This arm may only be used where nitrofurantoin is unsuitable for this patient and the reason has been recorded. It is not an alternative first choice.

Healthcare professionals covered, and training

- Pharmacist registered and practising with the GPhC.
- Pharmacy technician registered and practising with the GPhC.
- All users must be familiar with the current SPC for the product supplied, the BNF, and the NICE guideline on lower urinary tract infection in women (NG109) and NICE CKS.
- All users must be able to distinguish a lower urinary tract infection from pyelonephritis, and must know the red flags in Appendix 1 without looking them up.
- All users must be competent to take a sexual history sufficient to consider a sexually transmitted infection as an alternative diagnosis, and to refer for testing without embarrassment on either side.
- All users must previously have supplied medicines under a PGD.
- All users must understand capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.
- All users must be up to date with CPD and appraisal, and with MHRA safety alerts relating to these medicines.
- All users must hold appropriate indemnity covering this service, must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer, and must practise only within the bounds of their own competence.

The PGD

Indication	Treatment of uncomplicated lower urinary tract infection in a non-pregnant woman aged 16 to 64 years, where nitrofurantoin is contraindicated, not tolerated, or unavailable, and no red flag in Appendix 1 is present.
Gate on the use of this arm	Supply trimethoprim ONLY where one of the following applies, and record which: • Nitrofurantoin is contraindicated for this patient, for example G6PD deficiency or a previous nitrofurantoin reaction. • The patient has had an intolerable adverse effect on nitrofurantoin previously. • Nitrofurantoin is not available in the pharmacy and cannot be obtained the same day. Patient preference is NOT a reason to use this arm. Where trimethoprim was used in the last 3 months for any indication, do not supply it again. Resistance is likely. Refer.
Inclusion criteria	• Female, aged 16 to 64 years inclusive. • Two or more of: dysuria, new nocturia, urinary frequency or urgency. • Symptoms present for 7 days or fewer. • No red flag in Appendix 1 present. • The gate above is satisfied and the reason recorded. • Able to give valid informed consent, and consent given. • No exclusion criterion present.
Exclusion criteria	Refer, do not supply, where any of the following applies. • Male. Aged under 16 or 65 and over. • Pregnant, possibly pregnant, or breastfeeding. Trimethoprim is a folate antagonist and is teratogenic in the first trimester. Ask; do not assume. • ANY red flag in Appendix 1, INCLUDING any sign of upper urinary tract infection or pyelonephritis: fever, rigors, loin or flank pain, nausea or vomiting, visible haematuria, confusion, or appearing systemically unwell. • Known kidney disease, or renal function unknown in a patient aged 60 to 64. See the renal row below.

	• An indwelling urinary catheter, or a catheter removed within the last 7 days. • Recurrent UTI, meaning 2 or more episodes in the last 6 months or 3 or more in the last 12 months. • An antibiotic already taken for this same episode. One course per episode. Refer. • Symptoms present for more than 7 days. • Known hypersensitivity to trimethoprim or to any excipient in the product supplied. • Known folate deficiency, megaloblastic anaemia, or any blood dyscrasia. • Taking methotrexate. The combination causes profound marrow suppression and can be fatal. This is an absolute exclusion, not a caution. • Taking an ACE inhibitor, an angiotensin receptor blocker, spironolactone, eplerenone, amiloride or any other potassium-sparing agent. Trimethoprim causes hyperkalaemia and the combination has been associated with sudden death in older patients. • Taking phenytoin, azathioprine, ciclosporin, digoxin, repaglinide or dofetilide. • Taking warfarin or any other coumarin anticoagulant, unless the anticoagulation service has been consulted. Trimethoprim raises the INR. • Known hepatic impairment. • Vaginal discharge, pelvic pain, intermenstrual or post-coital bleeding, or a history suggesting a sexually transmitted infection. Refer for testing. • Known structural or functional abnormality of the urinary tract, renal stones, or immunosuppression. • Valid informed consent not obtained.
Renal function, how to assess it here	Ask the patient directly: "Have you ever been told you have kidney disease, or that your kidneys do not work as well as they should?" • Answer YES, or the patient is under any renal follow-up: EXCLUDE. Refer. • Answer NO and aged 16 to 59: proceed. • Answer NO but aged 60 to 64, or the patient does not know: EXCLUDE. Refer for a renal function check first.
Cautions	Take the doses at evenly spaced intervals, roughly 12 hours apart. Advise the patient to seek medical advice promptly for sore throat, fever, mouth ulcers, bruising or bleeding, which may indicate a blood disorder. Advise the patient to complete the full 3 day course even if symptoms settle sooner. Encourage fluids and offer paracetamol or ibuprofen for pain as a separate pharmacy sale, subject to the usual checks.
Actions if the patient is excluded or declines	Explain why supply is not appropriate and what to do instead. Direct to the GP the same day where a red flag is present, or to NHS 111 or urgent care out of hours. Give the 48 hour and immediate-action advice regardless of whether anything is supplied. Document the advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate.
Safety netting, to be given to every patient	48 HOURS. Tell the patient, in these terms: "If you are no better in 48 hours, or you get worse at any point, contact your GP or NHS 111 the same day. Do not wait." Tell the patient to seek help IMMEDIATELY, not in 48 hours, if any of the following develops: • A temperature, shivering or shaking uncontrollably.

	• Pain in the back or side, below the ribs. • Feeling sick or being sick. • Blood in the urine that they can see. • Confusion, drowsiness, or feeling very unwell in themselves. • Any new pain or bleeding in pregnancy, if pregnancy is a possibility.
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The medicine

Name, form and strength	Trimethoprim 200mg tablets.
Legal category	POM.
Dose and frequency	200mg twice daily for 3 days.
Quantity supplied	6 tablets. A 3 day course. No repeat supply under this PGD.
Route and method	Oral, with or without food.
Maximum treatment period	3 days. One course per episode. A patient still symptomatic at 48 hours is referred, not re-supplied.
Storage	Store below 25 degrees Celsius in a dry place.
Drug interactions	See the exclusion criteria. Methotrexate, potassium-sparing agents including ACE inhibitors and angiotensin receptor blockers, warfarin, phenytoin, azathioprine, ciclosporin, digoxin, repaglinide and dofetilide all interact and are handled as exclusions rather than cautions. Check the current SPC and BNF against the patient's full medicine list.
Adverse effects	Common: nausea, vomiting, diarrhoea, headache, rash, pruritus. Uncommon: hyperkalaemia, raised creatinine. Rare but serious: blood dyscrasias including megaloblastic anaemia, agranulocytosis and thrombocytopenia, severe cutaneous reactions including Stevens-Johnson syndrome, aseptic meningitis, liver enzyme abnormalities.
Yellow Card reporting	Report suspected adverse reactions via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP.
Records to be kept	• That valid informed consent was given. • Patient name, address, date of birth, and the GP with whom they are registered. • The symptoms present, and how long they have been present. • That the red flags in Appendix 1 were asked about and were absent. • The answer given on known kidney disease, and the answer given on previous episodes in the last 6 and 12 months. • Which medicine was supplied and why. Where trimethoprim was supplied, the reason nitrofurantoin was unsuitable. • Name, form, strength, dose, quantity and date of supply. • That 48 hour safety netting was given, and what the patient was told to do. • Name and registration number of the healthcare professional supplying. • Advice given, including advice given if the patient is excluded or declines. • Details of any adverse drug reactions and the actions taken. • That the medicine was supplied under this PGD. Records signed, dated, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records are acceptable. Adults aged 18 and over: keep for 8 years. Under 18s: keep until the 25th birthday, or the 26th birthday where the patient was 17 when treatment finished.

Disposal	Advise the patient to return any unused medicine to a pharmacy. Do not flush or place in household waste.
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Information for the patient

Written information	Supply the patient information leaflet provided with the product.
Counselling	• Take one tablet twice a day for 3 days, about 12 hours apart. Finish the course. • Drink plenty of fluids. • Paracetamol or ibuprofen can be used for the pain if they suit you. • Seek advice promptly if you get a sore throat, fever, mouth ulcers, unusual bruising or bleeding.
Follow-up	As set out in the safety netting row above. 48 hours, or immediately for any red flag symptom.

Appendix 1: Red flags. Ask every patient, before supplying anything

If ANY of these is present, do not supply. Refer the same day.

Fever, rigors, or shivering	• Suggests the infection has reached the kidney or the bloodstream. • A lower UTI does not cause fever. Refer.
Loin or flank pain, or back pain below the ribs	• Suggests pyelonephritis. • Refer the same day. A 3 day course will not treat it.
Nausea or vomiting	• Suggests upper tract involvement, and also means an oral antibiotic may not be absorbed.
Visible blood in the urine	• Refer. Visible haematuria requires investigation in its own right, and not only for infection. • Dipstick-only (non-visible) haematuria in a symptomatic woman is not by itself a red flag.
Confusion, new drowsiness, or feeling very unwell	• Possible sepsis. Refer urgently. • Out of hours, direct to NHS 111 or urgent care rather than waiting for the surgery.
Pregnancy, or pregnancy possible	• Refer. UTI in pregnancy carries risk to the pregnancy and needs a different antibiotic choice and a test of cure.
Symptoms for more than 7 days	• Refer for assessment and culture rather than empirical treatment.
Already treated for this episode	• One course per episode. Treatment failure needs culture, not a second guess. • Refer.
Catheter in place, or removed in the last 7 days	• Not uncomplicated UTI. Refer.
Recurrent UTI	• 2 or more episodes in 6 months, or 3 or more in 12 months. • Refer for investigation, whatever today's symptoms are.

Appendix 2: Key references

- NICE NG109: Urinary tract infection (lower), antimicrobial prescribing.
- NICE Clinical Knowledge Summary: Urinary tract infection (lower), women.
- Summary of Product Characteristics for nitrofurantoin 100mg modified release capsules and trimethoprim 200mg tablets, current versions.
- British National Formulary.
- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions.

Authorisation

Version	v002
Supersedes	Version 001, 25 June 2025
Valid from date	8 September 2026
Expiry date	31 July 2027

Doctor	Name: Nitin Shori
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	Job title: Medical Director, Get Real Health GMC: 6047293 Signed: N. Shori Date: 8 September 2026
Pharmacist	Name: Chris Pilkington Job title: Head Pharmacist, Get Real Health GPhC: 2046322 Signed: C. Pilkington Date: 8 September 2026

Both authorising signatories reviewed this version together on 8 September 2026 and gave their authorisation for it to be issued. Signatures were applied digitally on their joint instruction, which is the established process for Get Real Health PGDs.

Adoption by the employing organisation

To be completed by the adopting pharmacy. These signatories are the adopting organisation own signatories and must not be pre-filled by Get Real Health.

Superintendent / clinical lead	Name: Job title and organisation: Signature: Date:
Professional group signatory	Name: Job title and organisation: Signature: Date:

Change history

Version	v002
Date	8 September 2026
Changes	• Full clinical review and reissue. The clinically significant changes are listed below; re-read the document before working to it. • Safety netting is 48 hours, with a named list of symptoms requiring immediate action. • Nitrofurantoin is first line. Trimethoprim may be supplied only where nitrofurantoin is unsuitable, and the reason must be recorded. • Renal assessment is by direct question about known kidney disease, with exclusion where the answer is unknown in a patient aged 60 to 64. • New exclusions in both arms: indwelling or recently removed urinary catheter; recurrent UTI, defined as 2 or more episodes in 6 months or 3 or more in 12 months; an antibiotic already taken for this episode; visible haematuria; male patients; and a history suggesting a sexually transmitted infection. • Upper urinary tract infection is now an exclusion in the trimethoprim arm as well as the nitrofurantoin arm. • G6PD deficiency is an exclusion in the nitrofurantoin arm. • Trimethoprim interactions are handled as exclusions rather than cautions, and now cover potassium-sparing agents including ACE inhibitors and angiotensin receptor blockers, warfarin, phenytoin, azathioprine, ciclosporin, digoxin, repaglinide and dofetilide as well as methotrexate. Trimethoprim used within the last 3 months bars this arm. • One course per episode. A patient still symptomatic at 48 hours is referred, not re-supplied. • Red flags are collected in Appendix 1 and must be asked before any supply, with a record that they were asked and absent.

Previous versions

001, 25 June 2025	Development and issue of new PGD. Nitrofurantoin and trimethoprim arms, women aged 16 to 64.
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